Presentation Delivery: Format and Ground Rules

Digitalist Papers Essays — How You Will Present

ECON 470 — Microeconomics of Artificial Intelligence

Spring 2026

1 The short version

- **No slides.** You will present without a deck.
- **No reading.** You will not read your presentation from a page or a screen.
- **Notes are fine.** You may hold pieces of paper with notes — not full sentences meant to be read aloud. It cannot be a phone or a tablet.
- **Up to three exhibits, if you need them.** If your essay hinges on a chart, table, or equation that is genuinely hard to convey in words, you may bring one printed copy per classmate with the exhibits or put the exhibits on the board.

That is the format. The rest of this handout explains why, and how to prepare for it.

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2 Why we are doing it this way

You might be wondering why a course that is literally about artificial intelligence would ask you to present without the slickest tools on your laptop. Three reasons.

1. It rewards understanding over production. Anyone can make a nice-looking deck. Not everyone can stand up and explain — in their own words — what an essay argues and why it might be wrong. The second skill is harder and more valuable. Removing slides removes the place where under-prepared presentations usually hide.

2. It levels the playing field. Some students are practiced designers; some are not. Grading slide aesthetics ends up grading something that has nothing to do with economics. Without slides, what you are evaluated on is the thinking and the delivery — both of which you can improve with practice, which is the point.

3. It is a real skill. Every economist you admire can stand in front of a whiteboard and explain an argument without a deck. Seminar talks, job talks, policy briefings, client meetings — this is how ideas actually get transmitted in your field. You are practicing the format professionals use when the stakes are real.

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3 You can do this

If the first thought reading this was "I am going to forget everything the moment I stand up," that is normal. Here is the honest reassurance: students who prepare for this format do fine. The ones who struggle are the ones who try to memorize a script. The ones who succeed are the ones who *learn the argument well enough to explain it three different ways*, and then pick whichever way comes out on the day.

You have time. Twenty minutes of material. Two people to share the load. This is doable.

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4 How to prepare (the method that works)

This is the preparation method that reliably produces good no-slides presentations. Follow it even if you think you have a better way. You probably do not yet.

4.1 Step 1: Understand the essay cold

Before you think about *presenting*, you have to understand what you are presenting. Read the essay twice. On the second read, write down:

- The **one-sentence question** the essay is trying to answer
- The **three-to-five-step argument** the author makes, in order
- The **one move** in that argument you find least convincing

If you cannot do this without looking at the essay, you do not understand it yet. Read it again.

4.2 Step 2: Build a skeleton, not a script

Your preparation document is an **outline**, not a speech. Aim for one page. It should look like this:

- Question (one line)
- Argument: step 1 (two-to-three words), step 2, step 3, step 4
- Gans concept: which one, where it connects
- Critique: the move you push on, one line
- Two discussion questions

That is it. If your outline has full sentences, trim them to phrases. If it runs more than one page, cut. The outline is a *map*, not a *script*.

4.3 Step 3: Talk it out loud, three times

This is the step people skip. Do not skip it.

- **First time:** alone, at your desk, working from the outline. You will be terrible. This is fine. Notice where you get stuck and fix the outline.
- **Second time:** to your teammate, trading sections. You will be less terrible. Give each other honest feedback.
- **Third time:** to someone who has not read the essay — a roommate, a friend, a family member on the phone. If they come away understanding the argument, you are ready.

After three out-loud run-throughs, you will not need to memorize anything. The argument will live in your head because you have built it three times.

4.4 Step 4: On the day

- Bring your one-page outline.
- Place it somewhere visible (lectern, podium, desk).
- Glance at it between sections, not during them. Eye contact with the outline signals to the audience that you are consulting notes, which is fine. Eye contact with the outline for thirty seconds signals that you are reading, which is not.
- If you lose your place, stop, look at the outline, find it, continue. Silence is not a catastrophe. Panic is.

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5 What "no reading" actually means

We want to be precise about this so you can prepare without anxiety about where the line is.

Allowed:

- Glancing at an outline or keyword list to remember what section comes next
- Reading a *direct quote* from the essay (one or two sentences, clearly attributed to the author)
- Reading a *citation* or *statistic* exactly as it appears in the source
- Writing a key equation, term, or name on the whiteboard as you speak

Not allowed:

- Reading full sentences of your own prose from a page or screen
- Reciting a memorized script word-for-word in a way that makes it obvious you are performing rather than explaining
- Holding up your laptop or phone and reading from it

The spirit of the rule is simple: *you should be explaining the essay, not performing a text you wrote about it.* If a stranger walked into the room, they should see a person thinking and talking, not a person reading.

6 Grading and expectations

You are not being graded on polish. A presentation with a few "um"s, a lost-place moment recovered gracefully, and a genuine argument about the essay will score higher than a smooth recitation that does not say anything.

The rubric rewards:

1. **Clear framing** — can we tell what question the essay is answering?
2. **Accurate explanation** — do you get the author's argument right?
3. **Real connection to Gans** — are you using course vocabulary because it fits, or because you are supposed to?
4. **Actual critique** — do you have a view, and can you defend it?
5. **Discussion leadership** — do your questions get the class talking?

None of these require slides. All of them reward preparation.

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7 A final note

The students who do best on this assignment are not the most confident public speakers. They are the ones who understood their essay the most deeply. Depth is something you can build in a week of careful reading and three run-throughs. Confidence will follow.

If you are anxious, come to office hours. I can help you.